

modern fantasy writers

7 ppo

MARION ZIMMER BRADLEY (1930-1999)

Marion Zimmer Bradley was a sci fi and fantasy fan from her middle teens. In 1952 she sold her first story. She is known for writing science fiction, fantasy, gothics but is probably best known for her DARKOVER SERIES of 25 novels, written in various parts of Darkovers history, and a dozen anthologies, beginning in 1962. However, her Arthurian stories, MISTS OF AVALON, (now a 2 part mini-series on TNT), and its prequels, THE FOREST HOUSE, LADY OF AVALON, AND THIS YEAR, PRIESTESS OF AVALON are also well known.

She also edited a fantasy magazine, which has 50 issues from 1988 to 2000, and edited sword and sorcery anthologies for the past 11 years before she died of a massive heart attack in Sept., 1999.

^{and} There ~~will be~~ three more Darkover novels set early in the planets founding to be published posthumously ~~starting this year~~. They are being completed by other writers who know her style and story so should be true to her ideas.

With this introduction, let's get into religion in her stories of Darkover.

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DARKOVER

MARION ZIMMER BRADLEY

Unlike some series, such as Dune, where religion is central to the theme of the tales, in the Darkover material religion creeps in around the edges.

The primary author of the Darkover series was Marion Zimmer Bradley, but, unlike many science fiction/fantasy collections, there are twelve volumes of short story anthologies with many different writers, tho Ms. Bradley had served as the editor of all these collections and has had her own short stories included as well.

These volumes date from 1962 to the present, a collection, including the novels, of over 30 books. Since she died in 1999, there are still three Darkover books in the process of coming out, finished by others who knew her world. Her last published book in the avalon series, The Priestess of Avalon, is about Helena, the mother of Constantine.

The DARKOVER SERIES is built on the lost ship theme, with separate evolution of culture based on telepathic abilities developed on the new, metal poor, planet: at least two types of other sentient beings, both with telepathic abilities, and one with the ability to inter-breed with humans, exist on Darkover.

In many volumes, the conflict and cultural clash ^{that ensues} when the lost colony is rediscovered several thousand years later by the larger galactic government which includes Earth *is of great dramatic interest*

There are four areas where religion is given significant development.

1. religion which was brought with the lost ship and is reinterpreted through events and tradition.
2. The development of a telepathic aristocracy and the reverence, bordering on worship by the common people, of this group known as COMYN or equals, and their powers.

3. From the myths of the lost ship and the gradual development of the Comyn, a myth of origin in poetic form developed which held the form of household religion for most of those not still following the derived religion brought on the lost ship.

4. Finally, the planet called Darkover has 4 moons, and, as is mentioned in passing by those rediscovering Darkover, monotheism is impossible in a world that has 4 moons (in fact they have 4 goddesses).

This characteristic "what if?" development in fantasy or science fiction provides for several areas of intellectual exploration within the themes developed in the Darkover books.

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The Religion which preserves traditions from the lost ship is that of the
CHRISTOFOROS, named after Fr. Valentine of the order of St. Christofer, who was the surviving chaplain on the lost ship.

One of the characteristics of Darkover is the openness to sexuality, both due to the need of the survivors of the lost ship to maximize genetic diversity within their relatively small numbers, and to the inability to totally conceal feelings when telepathic communication was a fact of life.

Thus the priest, Fr. Valentine, when exposed to the hallucinagenic/ aphrodisiac telepathic pollen of the golden bell flower, discovers sex. He also discovers that his sexual orientation is forbidden by the church and kills all his sexual partners, as in his drug induced mind, this is a lesser evil than facing his own sexuality.

In due time he retreats to the edge of the glacier ^{Darkover is in an ice age} to escape the world, in the process founding what becomes in time the monastery of St. Valentine of the Snows, a primary source of written learning in a society that has other, more pressing needs for survival.

DARKOVER

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An excellent non Zimmer Bradley short story recounts how formal investigation is directed to Darkover millennia later, by the church authorities, to determine the validity of this group, only to find, in latin, Fr. Valentine's journal with all the truth of the events, and for the cheif investigator to also confront, in this more open society, his own sexual orientation.

The Christoforos are often used as a foil to contrast the problems of taught ethics when confronted with telepathy and other powers allowing the truth of the situation to be seen in spite of learned behaviour. Their discipline, tho, is often shown as used by the Comyn, which, tho not sharing the religious beliefs, send their young sons to St. Valentine of the Snows to learn self-discipline and thre rudiments of writing.

However, only those considered to have weak eyes or little telepathy, or other limitations are encouraged to devote their time to book learning as this does not have enough survival value for the society as a whole.

From in-breeding with the indigenous non-human telepaths, the Cheri, and the development of already latent telepathic human abilities increased by selective breeding, a class of interrelated aristocracy developed with different houses having different powers of telepathy.

These Comyn had to learn how to control their powers both in receiving and in broadcasting telepathy. The result was a different set of ethics developed, as well as a different perspective on religion.

Lying was impossible one to another as well as any statement of the so called "head blind" who attempted to lie. Thus the Comyn served as witnesses to the truth of a statement.

Through their abilities and the enhancement of such through a local gemstone or crystal matrix which magnified their psychic power these persons came to lead their respective communities. Certain families had special gifts such as healing, seeing some of the future, communication with non-human creatures, bringing about the awakening of these telepathic powers in others who had the ability but had not learned how to use or the awareness of use of this telepathy, and the forcible communication of mind to mind.

The common people, without these abilities, revered this class as both nobility and demi-gods. They trusted in them as the comyn could bring rain to forest fires to extinguish them, mine metals (of which there were few), communicate across distances, and often provide honorable government, though, as always, this was subject to abuse.

This developed among the common people into an acquiescing to the comyn as to religious figures. The central workers, the keepers, who directed this power from the great crystal matrixes located in towers to various things like mining, occupied a special position, with special dress and actions, akin to priestesses in reverence.

These sheilded towers came to be seen as religious centers in the understanding of the common people, with no admission for those not possessing telepathic powers. The fairly recent tradition of only virgin women being used for the center of this matrix technology for purposes of controlling the focused power of several workers increased the appearance of religious qualities to the outside viewer.

The attempt to break the control of tradition and allow others to use and even to serve as centers of this power becomes an heretical movement as one of the almost religious themes developed in these books.

This society as a whole was violent, but at one time the matrix technology had developed weapons of mass destruction to such a degree that the whole society was threatened.

A compact was agreed upon which banned use of weapons by the comyn or others beyond the reach of the individual. This was similar to the general consenses of today which has not used nuclear weapons since 1945 despite the spread of this technology.

Thus, when rediscovered by the Terran empire they are considered backward because they use swords and knives only as weapons. Those of Darkover, however, see this as a very significant ethical, almost religious, improvement and view the Terran space travelers as barbarians in using guns and other weapons that reach beyond the limit of personal danger.

Soon after the rediscovery of Darkover by the Terran empire, under instructions from the comyn, all mention of the matrix workers and telepathy is forbidden, and this special area of knowledge is concealed from the empire, giving the rule of the comyn even more of a religious and mysterious aspect from the vantage point of the empire and increasing the lack of communication between the two groups.

28 THE KIRESETH FLOWER, OR GOLDEN BELL

from the first experience of the blooming of the kireseth flower, the golden bell, a few days after the crash of the lost ship, throughout the long history of Darkover, the experience of this powerful pollen permeates the stories just as it overpowers the minds of those breathing it in significant quantities.

Fortunately the blooming is rather rare, dependent on unusual weather conditions. There is, of course, illegal usage of this drug, as in all cultures, and one

extract is used by the comyn in the towers and during training of young people to lower their barriers to telepathic work.

However, remnants of the importance of this drug are preserved in the folk religion and folk art, the recovery of which becomes a heresy to the towers and the freeing for telepathic work to those breaking the taboos.

The Ballad of Hastur and Cassilda, preserved in folk song, recounts the descent from on high of Hastur, Lord of Light. The presence of the golden flower in the verse indicates the ability of this drug to encourage sexual activity between god and human, where a child is given which is of both.

The actual history of Darkover has several times where the "Ghost Wind", the pollen of the golden bell, has brought about offspring of humans and the cheri, the highly telepathic, highly intelligent but dwindling older humanoid group on Darkover.

Thus the ballad and the art work in various house shrines showing one of the human sisters who welcomed Hastur holding a cluster of the flowers, served to preserve history as it became simple folk religion. This, in one book, served to provide the information necessary to successfully combat the charge of heresy in breaking from the old ways.

A folk song on the golden bell, and of a great keeper, killed because sh proved the old faith to be wrong, and also named for the flower, is entitled Golden bell, or Cliendori. (Next page)

Flowers are also part of the folk-religion with fertility overtones. At the time of marriage and when conception is desired flowers are placed in the family shrine

GOLDEN BELL

Words and Music by Cynthia Mc Quillin



A~G~A~G

The dawn blazed red this Summer's day,

And the valleys all in stillness lay, today.

Above in the heights the flowers bloom,

For some the wind will whisper doom, today.

For it's warm and dry as a maid may please

And the Golden Bell set's her pollen free, today.

Soon some may die and some may weep.

And some forget what others keep, today.

Across the fields in wild array,

Delusion fraught, the Ghost Winds play today;

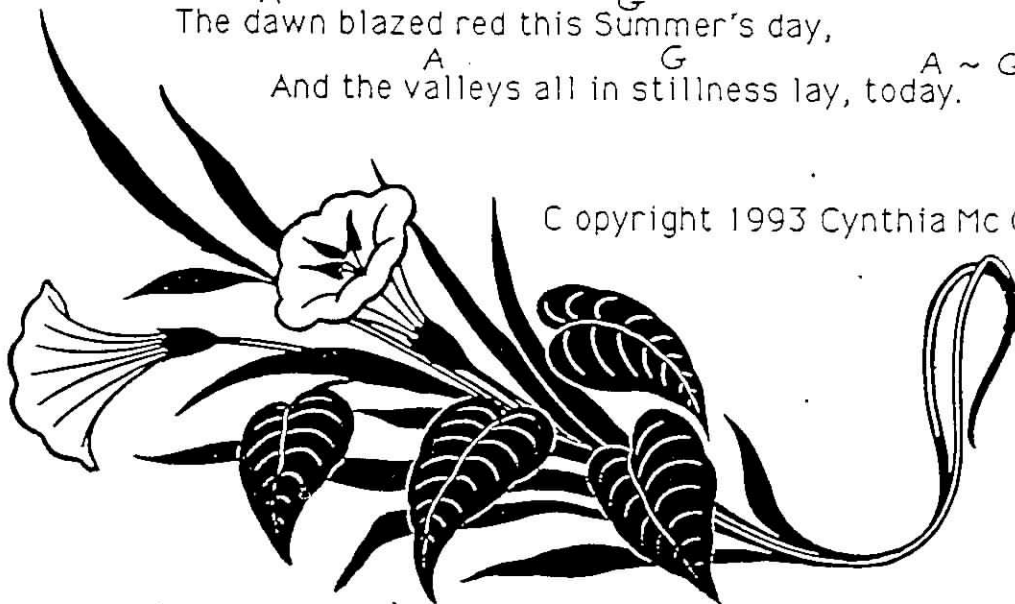
And so it is the elders tell

Of Cliendori, the Golden Bell, today.

The dawn blazed red this Summer's day,

And the valleys all in stillness lay, today.

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by the ladies of the house. Flowers and fruit are also gifts on the mid-summer's day celebration, which is a rather uninhibited festival of warmth and fertility in the rare warm season of the year.

Mention of the goddess here and in expressions of concerns for life and for death appear, but full worship ceremonies do not seem to be particularly important.

HALI:

In the folk piety there is also Hali, the burial place for the comyn and also the place of safekeeping for some of the old weapons from previous ages which proved too dangerous to destroy.

This multiple shielded shrine reflects both the dangers of the ages before the compact and the positive heritage of the people, preserved again in proverb and ballad, of information from the past which must be usable in the future for survival.

In two of the novels there appear the crows, the old women determining the destiny and the future of Darkover. Somehow this seems to be a side road which is not productive for the general plot of the series.

COTTAM 4: DARKOVER

A number of changes in the world of Darkover account for various ethical and religious changes. Because of the four moons there are multiple goddesses that are part of the common religion. The planet is in an ice age, so Hell is cold.

Because of the interbreeding with the other sentient beings on Darkover, the common insults of parentage do not exist there, regardless of legal status of the union.

Because of the poor soil and fire danger even feuds and warfare are suspended in order to combat forestfires.

yes In most of the history of Darkover, women have been considered property, in part because of the need to reproduce fast enough for survival in a marginal environment.

The revolt of the RENUNCIATES, called by the empire "Free Amazons", not long before the rediscovery of Darkover by the larger civilization, brings into play many plot possibilities of the interworking of sexual relationships, ownership, power, and the true value of the individual.

The impact of the rediscovery produces some of the most interesting ethical discussion in examining the role of cultures in conflict and the need to respect "lower" cultures. The very question of what constitutes "lower" in terms of ethics and morality certainly contrasts to our "western" culture on Terra which has so often abused differing thought systems.

The whole Darkover series is very enjoyable in large part for the effort to see ethics and relationships in a slightly altered direction, a "what if" for the rules dominant in our own society.

The ability of religion to shift to meet new circumstances is of interest. the pronounced change in thought and action upon the presence of telepathy and psi powers and this impact on religion as well as common behavior is an additional aspect of the interest of these books.

7 pages

THE MARTIAN CHRONICLES by Ray Bradbury

Probably Bradbury's most famous work, this was made into a mini series over 27 years ago. It runs 5 hours and 15 min.

The stories that comprise the chronicles are short stories by Bradbury which were published in magazines over a period of time. He put them together in 1950 as The Martian chronicles.

They document humans first colonization on Mars and what happens to those who were indigenous to Mars.

Apparently the first expedition in 1999 took with them Chicken pox which wiped out most of the humanoid martians. Later expeditions came and discovered the few left.

Missionaries also came from the Episcopal church and in a short story not originally part of the Martian Chronicles, tells of these two priests and their discovery. This story, included in the film, comes from Bradburys book The Illustrated Man and is called "The Fire Balloons".

~~After showing a short cut from the 4th expedition (June, 2001) where one of the expedition discovers and is taken over by one of the last Martians, the film will show the whole story of "The Fire Ballons" with a followup of the priest and what happens to the Martians. The total running time is about 40 min.~~

DVD - side 2 * * * * * 5-8 - Fire Balloons = 30 min
Scenes 5-11

THE MAN BY RAY BRADBURY (1948)

An expedition headed by a capt. Hart lands on a planet near a city. Nobody comes out to meet thejm and he is mad. Capt. Hart is a driven man, eats and sleeps little and looks older than his years. Very tense. as he says: There has been no rest on Earth since Darwin so humans are looking for peace and quiet among the stars.

He sends a fellow officer, Martin, into town to find the mayor and get them out to greet them. Martin returns saying they are not interested in coming because something big happened yesterday in their city.

A man had come for whomn they had waited a very long time, maybe millenea, so their rocket landing means nothing.

The capt. thinks its another one of his expedition of three ships, Burton or Ashley, trying to upstage him.

Hart wants to know whats so great about this man. Martin says he heals the sick, comforts the poor and fights hypocrisy and dirty politics and talks to the people.

Hart still doesn't get it, then it dawns on him but he says he doesn't believe it. They go into the city, sets up a universal translator and a recorder and talks to the mayor. He wants proof but he never believes what he is told.

Martin, tired of the Capts. petty tyranny, says he is staying

The capt. interviews 3 dozen people and still thinks it is Burton or Ashley at work. However, a gong sounds and Burton and Ashleys ships are just arriving. They had been in a cosmic storm and most the crews plus the two captains are dead.

This means that the Man was who people said he was and the Capt. heads back to the city. It is implied that the Man has already left and the capt. demands to know where he has gone.

The mayor says he doesn't know but Hart thinks he is hiding him. He gets so angry he shoots the mayor in the arm. The mayor says to him: You've never believed and now that you think you believe, you hurt people because of it."

Hart gets hysterical, plans to go from planet to planet till he finally catches up with him.

Martin escorts him to the ship but says he is staying there as are 7 of the 10 crew members.

Martin asks what he will ask him if he finds him. Hart answers: "a little peace and quiet" to which Martin replies, haven't you ever tried to relax?

After the ship leaves, the Mayor reveals that the Man is, in fact, there in the city and waiting for them.

* * * * *

Why did they keep the Man's presence from capt. Hart (and the crew) until Hart left?

any other comments?

THE MAN is still one of the best variations on two old Christian themes: The search for the historical Jesus, and the speculation that Christ might repeat his mission to other beings on other planets.

Now to end here is part of a long lyrical "cantata" by Bradbury which explores the eternally repeating Christ called "Christus Apollo"

skip if not time
CHRISTUS APOLLO by Ray Bradbury

In some far universal Deep
Did He tread Space
and visit worlds beyond our blood-warm dreaming"
Did He come down on lonely shore by tsea
Not unlike Galilee
And are there mangers on far worlds that knew His light?
And virgins?
Sweet Pronouncements?
Annunciations? Visitations from angelic hosts?

And, shivering vast light among ten billion lights;
Was there some Star much like the star at Bethlehem
That struck the sight with awe and revelation
Upon a cold and most strange morn?

On worlds gone wandering and lost from this
Did Wise Men gather in the dawn
In cloudy steams of Beast
Within a place of straw now quickened to a Shrine
To look upon a stranger Child than ours?

How many stars of Bethlehem burnt bright?
Beyond Orion or Centauri's blinding arc?
How many miracles of birth all innocent
Have blessed those worlds?

Does Herod tgremble there
In dread facsimile of our dark and murderous King?
Does that mad keeper of an unimaginable realm
Send stranger soldiers forth
To slaughter down the Innocents
Of lands beyond the Horsehead Nebula?

It must be so,
For in this time of Christmas
In the long Day totalling up to eight,
We see the light, we know the dark;
And creatures lifted, born, thrust free of so much night
No matter what the world or time or circumstance
MUST love the light,
So, children of all lost unnumbered suns
Must fear the dark.
Which mingles in a shadowing-forth on air.
And swarms the blood.
No matter what the color, shape, or size
Of beings who keep souls like breathing coals
In long midnights,
They MUST need saving of themselves.
So on far worlds in snowfalls deep and clear
Imagine how the rounding out of some dark year
Might celebrate with birithing one miraculous child!

Born in Andromeda's out-swept mysteries?
Then count its hands, its fingers,
Eyes, and most incredible holy limbs!
The sum of each?
No matter, Cease.
Let Child be fire as blue as water under Moon.
Let Child sport free in tides with human-seeming fish.
Let ink of octopi inhabit blood
Let skin take acid rains of chemistry
All falling down in nightmare storms of cleansing burn.

Christ wanders in the Universe
A flesh of stars,
He takes on creature shapes
To suit the mildest elements,
He dresses him in flesh beyond our ken.
There He walks, glides, flies, shambling of strangeness.
Here He walks Men.

Among the ten trillion beams
A billion Bible scrolls are scored
In hieroglyphs among God's amplitudes of worlds;
In alphabet multitudinous
Tongues which are not quite tongues
Sigh, sibilate, wonder, cry:
As Christ comes manifest from a thunder-crimsoned sky.

He walks upon the molecules of seas
All boiling stews of beast
All maddened broth and brew and rising up of yeast.
There Christ by many names is know.
We call him thus.
They call him otherwise.
His name on any mouth would be a sweet surprise.
He comes with gifts for all,

Here: winde and bread.
there: nameless foods
At breakfasts where the morsels fall from stars
And Last Suppers are doled forth 2with stuff of dreams.
So sit they there in times before the Man is crucified.
Here He has long been dead.
There He has not yet died.

Science Fiction and religion, #6

watch THE BELIVERS, A BAB 5 episode.

discuss being chosen

ethics in doctors dilemma

idea of losing spirit if cut open

(natives feeling their spirit was stolen if took a picture of them)

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Voyager - start by 8:10

Discuss:

~~DRAGON'S EGG~~

a neutron star caused by a super nova some 500,000 years ago with gravity 67 billion times that of earth with 4 poles.

there is a 2 kilo thick mantle covering the star over a liquid core.

as star cools, the mantle cracks producing some mountains from a few millimeters to 10 cent. high.

it spins at a little over 5 revolutions per second.

At this point (2050 A.D.) it is 1/30th of a light year from our solar system.

life evolves and lives about one million times faster than human life.

thus a long life on Dragon's egg is about 45 minutes in human time.

When the humans arrive, life is just evolving (humans have no idea)

The Cheela evolved from plants and are as complex and intelligent as humans. They are flat, amoeba like creatures with eye pods measuring @ 2.5mm in radius and .5mm high and are very dense. They are flexible so they can slide over the surface and can't raise very high due to the gravity. They must move along magnetic field lines.

According to thier ancient myths they are descended from a "Chosen clan" that was driven from the Northern hemisphere by a

hateful dragon god, who lived inside a volcano. They were driven to the south where they found a land of plenty, with many edible plants and animals but no cheela.

The chosen clan discovered a bright star sitting over the south pole (our sun) and a monotheistic religion began based on the worship of the God Bright.

When the humans arrived in their ship the Cheela believed it was Brights messenger. This made their astrology more complex and as a result, writing was developed to keep track.

two Earth days later, (about 4800 years to the Cheela) 6 glowing masses were dropped to compensate for the high gravity. They were interpreted as new stars. A new religion-polytheistic-sprang up that involved orgies and other things which upset the priesthood of the one god Bright. The 6 new stars were called: East, west, sky, crust, food and sex.

When the humans re-set them closer to the star, the Cheela believed they were being punished by Bright and returned to his worship. The High priest took advantage of this saying they were Brights eyes watching to see that the Cheela didn't worhip false gods again. The human ship (Brights messenger) moves to the center of the objects and in actuality, they are all in synchronous orbit above Dragon's egg.

As the humans begin mapping the star using lasers one small cheela, aa runt with poor eyes, insists that Bright is talking to him. He was rejected and wandered away when he saw another multicolored beam. He moves toward it and when it hits him he goes into ecstasy, feeling it was like having sex with a god.

He spends dozens of turns (1 turn = aprox .2 seconds = 1 of our days. However, the Cheela never sleep so they waste no time) communing with the inner light of Bright and follows the beam back to his camp where he proclaims he has been called to bring the Word of Bright to the Cheela.

"Prepare for the blessing of Bright", "Repent and pray"

He pulls out his clan totem and declares he is no longer of this clan.

When the laser hits the camp, they are all put into ecstasy and converted and Pink eyes, as he is known, goes out to convert the other clans. When asked if he was a god he says no, only God's chosen "Bright is god, I am merely brights vehicle by which he sends his word and his blessings.

he converts the head of all the clans who builds a great temple. Unfortunately for him, the laser survey ends for that section of the star and when they all gather for Bright's blessing there is none. He is arrested by the high priest and tho he can see the new beam he knows it is far to the north and that the barbarians are now receiving the blessing of Bright.

He is killed still asking for Brights blessing on the cheela. however, as a runt, even his meat is abandoned.

The humans spot the temple as it was very large, and interpret it as having to be built by intelligent life. They begin to use a beam to signal the cheela and the Cheela realize that something intelligent is signaling from Bright.

Their science advances very rapidly by human standards and they spend 1.2 seconds (=6 days) visiting the humans. They quickly surpass them and are traveling all over the galaxy in ships that exceed light speed. Even going into our sun and repairing a black hole that makes it unstable.

They impart all the information they have gathered, literally all there is to know about the universe, to the humans who will spend thousands of years catching up. end of book.

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ISSUES INVOLVED:

What causes religion in the first place? Can anything that produces awe be the cause? (Japan)

How something natural can be interpreted as supernatural by those who don't know. Could this have happened on Earth in our developing religions? Do more advanced cultures sometimes do this to primitive ones? (ex: the cargo cult of the Philipines)

Cargo cult - New Guinea